

Common Student Decisions (2-3 Minute Course)

1. Introduction (20-30 seconds)

- **Topic Introduction:** As a college student, managing money effectively is crucial for your academic success and well-being. In this lesson, we'll explore common decisions you may face regarding living arrangements, saving on textbooks, and resources for funding educational opportunities like study abroad or conferences.
- **Objective:** You'll learn about the financial pros and cons of living on and off-campus, ways to save on common student expenses, and how to access financial resources to enhance your educational experience.

2. Living On-Campus vs. Off-Campus (40-50 seconds) (2)

- **On-Campus:**
 - **Pros:** Living on campus offers convenience—close proximity to classes, campus resources, and meals. If you're on a scholarship, some housing costs may be covered, which can make it easier to manage. Plus, you can get an on-campus job minimizing the stress of the cost of gas and finding ways to get to work.
 - **Cons:** However, on-campus housing tends to be more expensive than off-campus options, and you often don't have much flexibility or space.
- **Off-Campus:**
 - **Pros:** Off-campus living is often cheaper. If you receive them, you can use refund checks from scholarships or student loans to pay rent, and technically, you can use that money for anything, like textbooks or personal expenses.
 - **Cons:** Off-campus living means more responsibility—managing leases, utilities, furniture, and commuting. Some rentals use joint leases, so if a roommate doesn't pay, you're still on the hook. If utilities aren't included, the person whose name is on the bill is fully responsible, even if others don't pay their share.
 - **Lease Buyout:** If you're renting off-campus, make sure to carefully review your lease agreement. Understanding a lease buyout option can be useful if you need to break the lease early. Be aware of any fees or financial consequences.
- **Tip:** If you don't have a scholarship for housing, living off-campus is generally the more affordable choice. If you *do* have a scholarship that covers more of your tuition, use that refund check wisely for rent and other expenses.

3. Saving on Common Expenses (40-50 seconds) (3)

- **Textbooks:**
 - Textbooks can be a big expense each semester, but there are ways to save. Check third-party sites like Chegg or AbeBooks, campus buy/sell groups on social media platforms like SnapChat and Instagram, and see if the library has a free eBook version. GVSU's Save program offers digital access, but make sure to opt out if you're not using it or found a cheaper

option. Rentals can sometimes save money, but compare prices carefully and don't forget to return them—but, buying used may be cheaper long-term.

- Pro Tip: Order books 2–3 weeks before classes start to avoid shipping delays and high last-minute prices.

- **Other Expenses:**

- Consider cutting costs on daily essentials and how to live below your means, such as groceries or transportation, by taking advantage of student discounts or sharing costs with roommates. Little savings here and there can add up quickly.

4. **Funding Educational Opportunities (40-50 seconds)**

- **Study Abroad:**

- Studying abroad can be a life-changing experience, but it's also expensive. Many universities offer scholarships or funding specifically for study abroad programs. Research these opportunities early to make your dream trip more affordable.

- **Conferences and Other Opportunities:**

- Conferences are a great way to network and learn, but they often come with registration and travel fees. Check with your academic department or student services to see if there are grants or scholarships available for these events.

- **Employer Tuition Assistance:**

- Many employers offer tuition assistance or reimbursement programs. If you're working part-time or even full-time, ask about educational benefits. This can help reduce the financial burden of your tuition.

5. **Emergency Funds (40-50 seconds)**

- **Building an Emergency Fund:**

- It's essential to have an emergency fund, even as a student. Unexpected expenses—like car repairs or medical bills—can arise. Start small by setting aside a portion of your income or refund check to build a financial cushion. Having an emergency fund can prevent you from going into debt when life throws a curveball.

6. **Conclusion and Takeaways (20-30 seconds)**

- **Summary of Key Points:**

- Deciding between on-campus and off-campus housing depends on your scholarship situation and personal preference. Off-campus living is usually cheaper and more flexible.
- Save on textbooks by purchasing from third-party websites and plan ahead for shipping times.
- Utilize resources like scholarships, employer tuition assistance, and grants to fund your education and opportunities.
- Understand your lease and aim to build an emergency fund to handle unexpected expenses.

- **Call to Action:**

Take a moment to review your current financial situation and see where you can save or make adjustments. Whether it's choosing the right housing, finding affordable textbooks, or exploring funding options for your education, small decisions now can lead to big savings down the road.

References:

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3. <https://collegemoneytips.com/powerful-methods-for-saving-money-for-college/>